

Have Been, Has Been and Had Been

In today's lesson, we're focusing on the often-confusing structures 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'. We'll break down these forms with practical examples and helpful tips, ensuring you understand their usage in different contexts. To make sure you've got it all down, we'll wrap up with a quiz to test your knowledge.

What will you learn in today's lesson?

This lesson is quite long and in-depth, so before we start, I'm going to tell you exactly what I'll be talking about so you know what to expect.

- **Subject-Verb Agreement:** understand which subjects pair with 'have', 'has' and 'had'.
- **Sentence Formation:** learn to construct positive and negative sentences and questions with 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'.
- **Pronunciation & Contractions:** master the pronunciation of these words and their contracted forms.
- **Key Uses Exploration:**
 - Discuss travel experiences
 - Describe ongoing states or actions, with a focus on 'for' and 'since'
 - Examine the narrative of two past events or actions
 - Employ the passive voice to highlight the object of a sentence
- **Additional Applications:** gain insight into the varied applications of 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'.
- **Quiz Time:** a short review of the quiz from the video lesson.

Are you ready to finally master **'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'**?

Let's get started with our first topic on the next page.



1 Subject-Verb Agreement

First, I'm going to talk about the basics. We use **'have been'** and **'has been'** in the present perfect tenses.

Here's a quick review of the present perfect constructions -

	Positive	Negative	Question
Present Perfect Simple	subject + have/has + past participle	subject + have/has + not + past participle	have/has + subject + past participle
	My mum has seen that film.	My mum has not seen that film.	Have you seen that film?
Present Perfect Continuous	subject + have/has + been + -ing verb	subject + have/has + not + been + -ing verb	have/has + subject + been + -ing verb
	We have been working there for years.	I haven't been working since the pandemic.	Has he been working online?

I, you, we, they and **plural nouns** go with **'have been'**.

- **I** have been
- **You** have been
- **The books** have been
- **My parents** have been

He, she, it and **singular** and **uncountable nouns** go with **'has been'**.

- **She** has been
- **It** has been
- **London** has been
- **The bread** has been (bread is uncountable)



And now let me refresh your memory of the past perfect tenses before we continue.

	Positive	Negative	Question
Past Perfect Simple	subject + had + past participle	subject + had + not + past participle	Had + subject + past participle
	Katherine had approved my time off before she left.	They had not been to that restaurant before I took them.	Had you done pottery before today?
Past Perfect Continuous	subject + had + been + -ing verb	subject + had + not + been + -ing verb	Had + subject + been + -ing verb
	I had been living in my dad's flat up until I moved to Madrid.	I hadn't been feeling well for a few days so I decided to go to the doctor's.	Had you been studying for your exams before the holiday started?

We use '**had been**' with **all subjects** in the **past perfect tenses**.

- I had been
- He had been
- Our children had been
- The tea had been

2 Positive and Negative Sentences and Questions

In **positive sentences**, the structure is -

positive = subject + have/has/had been... .

In **negative sentences**, we put 'not' between 'have, has or had' and 'been':



negative = subject + have/has/had not been... .

In **questions**, we invert the subject-verb order and put 'have, has or had' before the subject:

questions = Have/Has/Had + subject + been... ?

I want to note here that we can use '**been**' (to be) as a **main verb** or an **auxiliary verb**.

'been' as a main verb	'been' as an auxiliary verb
'Been' expresses the state or action being described. It is not followed by another verb.	'Been' adds grammatical information to a sentence. It is followed by a main verb
I have been to France.	I have been <u>studying</u> English for 3 years

3 Pronunciation and Contractions

Before we get started with how these words are used, I want to go over the pronunciation.

'**Been**' is pronounced **/bi:n/** or **/bɪn/**. Both are correct, but **/bɪn/** is very common in faster, informal speech. It's also very common for speakers to use contractions with have/has or had been. For example, **I have been...** often becomes -

- **I've been** ➡ /aɪv bi:n/
- or
- **I've been** ➡ /aɪv bɪn/

So, listen out for the contracted forms '**I've**', '**you've**', '**we've**' and '**they've**.'



The same thing happens with **'has been'**, which reduces to **/z/** or **/s/**, for -

- **He's been** ➔ /hi:z bi:n/
- **She's been** ➔ /ʃi:z bi:n/
- **It's been** ➔ /ɪts bi:n/

And **'had been'**, which contracts to **/d/**, for example -

- **I'd been** ➔ /aɪd bi:n/
- **He'd been** ➔ /hi:d bi:n/

Except with the contraction of **'it had'**, which contracts to **/'ɪtəd/**. Notice the extra **/ə/** sound there, which adds an extra syllable.

Finally, we often contract a noun with **'have/has/had been'**.

- **The books've been** ➔ /'bʊksəv bi:n/
- **London's been** ➔ /'lʌndənz bi:n/
- **Our children'd been** ➔ /'tʃɪldrənəd bi:n/

4 Uses

Travel Experiences

Now let's talk about the first and easiest use of **'have been'**, **'has been'** and **'had been'**. This might be the easiest but it's where a lot of my students get confused and make mistakes. We often use **'have been'**, **'has been'** and **'had been'** when talking about travel experiences. For example -

- Will **has been** to London many times.

Note that it's **'been to London'** but just **'visited London'** without **'to'**. That's a common mistake.

This means that Will has visited London many times in his life up until now.



- I've **been** to France three times.

I have visited France three times in my life until now and I might go again in the future. Here are some more examples.

- **Has** Verity **been** to Cardiff?
- Yes, she has [been to Cardiff].
- No, she hasn't [been to Cardiff].
- **Have** you **been** to Australia?
- Yes, I have [been to Australia].
- No, I haven't [been to Australia].

These answers are usually shortened to '**Yes, I have.**' and '**No, I haven't.**'

Please note that we **can't talk about specific times** with 'have/has been' to talk about general travel experiences. If you want to say exactly when something happened, use the **past simple**.

I **have been** to Australia last year. ✗

I **went** to Australia last year. ✓

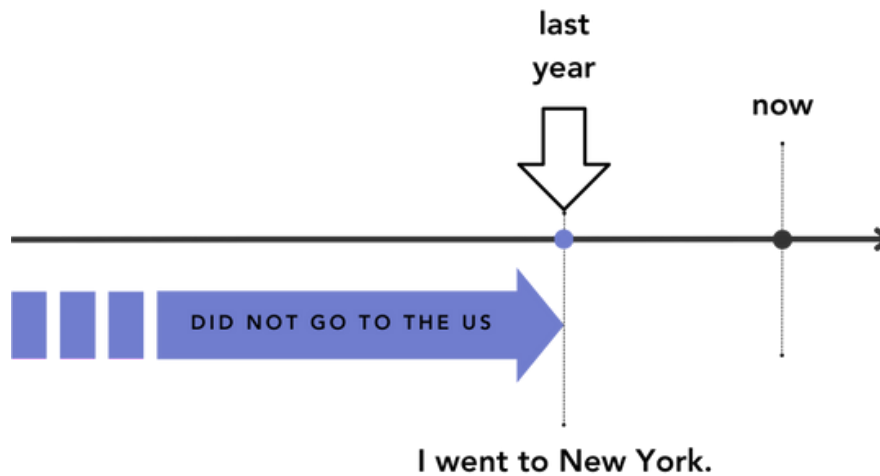
Now, I would like to mention something that lots of learners find confusing: '**have/has been**' and '**have/has gone**'.

have/has been	have/has gone
Use have/has been to say that someone went to a place and then returned. The visit is complete.	Use have/has gone to say that someone went to a place and has not returned.
Alicia has been to Mumbai.	Alicia has gone to Mumbai. She will be back next week.

You can also use '**had been**' when talking about travel experiences. We use 'had been' to say that **we travelled or didn't travel to a place before another event in the past**. For example -

- I **had never been** to the US before I visited New York last year.

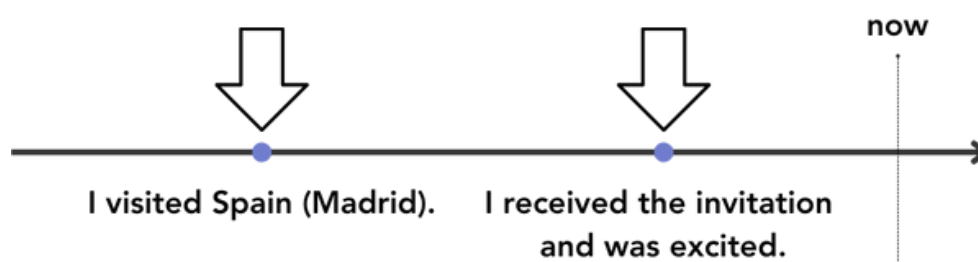
There are two past tenses here. 'I **had never been**' and 'I **visited**' both refer to the past. The sentence means that the first time in my life that I visited the US was when I went to New York last year.



Here's another example -

- I was excited to receive an invitation to their wedding in Barcelona. I **had been** to Spain before, but only to Madrid.

This sentence means that I received an invitation to the wedding in the past. I visited Spain at some point before I got the invitation, but not Barcelona, where the wedding was.



Unfinished States and Actions

In the next section, let's discuss the second use of 'have been' and 'has been'. We use 'have been' and 'has been' in the **present perfect simple** to talk about **states that started in the past and continue up to the present**.

For example -

- He **has been** a nurse for almost a year.
- He **has been** a nurse since last March.

He started working as a nurse last March and has had the job for almost a year. He is still a nurse now.

Here are some other common uses of the present perfect simple.

1	<u>To describe experiences and life events</u>
2	<u>To discuss recently completed actions</u>
3	<u>To talk about actions that happened at an unspecified time</u>

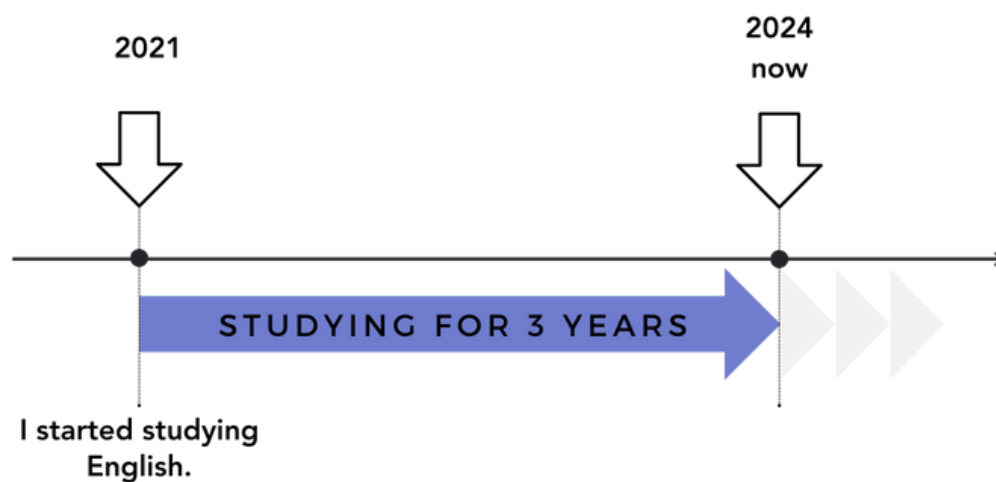
We use '**have been + -ing**' and '**has been + -ing**' in the **present perfect continuous** to talk about **actions that started in the past and continue up to the present**.

- I **have been studying** English for three years.
- I've **been studying** English since 2021.

2021 was my starting point for studying English. So, I started in 2021 and I have continued for three years until the present day. You don't know if I will continue studying English in the future. Using 'have been' or 'has been' does not tell you about the future.

Let's look at some of the other ways to use the present perfect continuous.

1	<u>To discuss actions with a result in the present</u>
2	<u>To emphasise the duration of actions</u>
3	<u>To talk about habits or repeated actions</u>
4	<u>To talk about processes or changes</u>



We often use the words **'for'** and **'since'** with the present perfect tenses. When we use **'for'**, we're talking about the duration of the activity or the period of time. So **'three years'** is how long I have been studying English. When we say **'since'**, we are talking about the starting point. So, I started studying English in 2021.

Now, here are some more example sentences -

- William **has been watching** TV since midday.
- William's **been watching** TV for three hours.
(presuming it's 3 in the afternoon)

In the first sentence, William started watching TV at midday and he is still watching TV now. In the second sentence, he started watching TV three hours ago and he is still watching now.

- We've **been** together for 7 years.
- We've **been** together since 2017.

We got together seven years ago, in 2017, and we are still together now.

Two Past Events or Actions

Now let's take a closer look at '**had been**'. I'm going to take the sentences that we used to learn 'have been' and 'has been' and show you how they're used with 'had been'. This will help you to see how the meaning changes.

Let's start with our sentence about studying English. Here it is with 'had been' in the past perfect continuous.

- I **had been** studying English for three years when I went to London last year.

There are two past actions here. One continuous past action, 'I had been studying English' and a single finished action, 'I went to London'.

Now, I want to compare that sentence with our previous one with 'have been'.

- I **have been** studying English for three years.

Here, there is one action that continues up to the present.

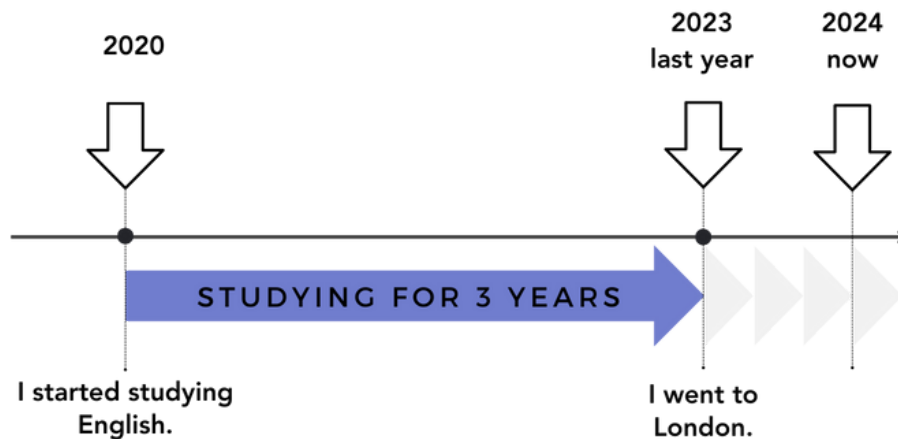
- I **had been** studying English for three years when I went to London last year.

We use 'had been' or 'had been + -ing' when there are two past events. The action with 'had been' began in the past and continued up to a more recent point in the past.



We use the **past simple** to talk about the action or event that happened second. In this case, the more recent point was 'last year' when I went to London.

We use the **past perfect continuous** for the action which happened first. We don't know if the action (studying English) continued beyond my trip.



Let's have a look at the other example sentences and change them to 'had been'.

- William **had been** watching TV for three hours when he stopped to do some housework.

The action 'had been watching' began first and continued until William realised it was time to start the housework.

- He'd **been** a nurse for 11 months when he quit his job.

In this case, he became a nurse and continued in the job for 11 months. Then he quit. This is an example of the **past perfect simple**. And the last example is a sad one :

- We **had been** together for 7 years when we broke up.

We were in a relationship for 7 years before we broke up.

The Passive Voice

Now, let's move on to the fourth and final use that I want to talk about in this video of 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been'. We use them in the **passive voice**.

Before we go any further, let's do a quick review of the passive voice. The passive voice is formed by combining the verb **'to be'** with the past participle. 'To be' indicates the tense in the passive voice.

Here are some more examples in different past, present and future tenses.

Active	Passive
Present Simple: Mark cleans the house daily.	Present Simple: The house is cleaned daily.
Past Continuous: They were writing a report.	Past Continuous: A report was being written.
Future Perfect: I will have washed the car by tomorrow.	Future Perfect: The car will have been washed by tomorrow.

Note that we don't typically use the passive voice in the **present perfect continuous, past perfect continuous** or **future perfect continuous** tenses.

It is common to use the passive voice -

1	<u>to focus on the object of a sentence</u>
2	<u>when the subject is unknown or unimportant</u>
3	<u>when the subject is obvious or not explicitly mentioned</u>
4	<u>to avoid responsibility or blame</u>

Alright, let's get back to the lesson. I tend to buy lots of things online for my dog, Diego. And, when I complete a purchase, I get an email saying,

- Your order **has been received**.

This sentence is in the passive voice. In the **active voice**, it would be -

- We **have received** your order.

The website uses the passive voice because 'we' (the seller) isn't important in this situation. The order is more important, so the focus of the sentence is on that.

After I've bought something, the shop sends my purchases to me. Then I often get a message from the courier saying this:

- Your parcel **has been** delivered.

Or, because I usually buy several things at once -

- Your parcels **have been** delivered.

The parcels are more important than the company or person who delivered them.

So, how do we use 'had been' in the passive voice?

This is quite advanced but it's important that you know it because I'm sure you will hear it.

We use 'had been' in the passive voice when there are two actions in the past. For example -

- My van **had been** repaired by the mechanic so it was as good as new.

Both of the events or actions were in the past. The first event that occurred is indicated with '**had been**' and the second with the **past simple**. So first the mechanic repaired my car and then it was as good as new.

Let's look at another example.

- By the time we arrived at the hotel, all the rooms **had been** booked for the night.

Again, we have two events in the past. First, people booked all of the rooms and then we arrived at the hotel. Very poor planning.

5 Extra Information

In this final section, I want to give you some extra information about when you will see 'have been', 'has been' and 'had been' used. I'm not going to explain these uses in great detail, but I want you to be aware of them.

- '**Have been**' after modal verbs

- We see 'have been' (but not 'has been') appear after modal verbs like '**might**' and '**must**'. Using 'have been' with different modal verbs could be a whole video in itself, so here are just a couple of examples -
 - Maria **might have been** in Ghana last month. She goes every year in January.
 - He **must have been** at work when you tried to call him.

- **The third conditional**

- You will also see 'have been' after a modal verb in the third conditional.
 - I **would have been** happy if you had come.
- And we use 'had been' in the third conditional, too.
 - If I **had been** to Greenland before, I **would have** told you about it.

- **'Has-been' as a noun**

- The final thing I want to draw your attention to is the use of 'has-been' /'hæz bi:n/ as a noun! Notice that there is a hyphen between 'has' and 'been'. A 'has-been' is a person who was important, famous or very good at something in the past but isn't any more. It's not a very nice thing to call someone, but you should recognise the word even if you don't use it.

6 Quiz Review

1. She has been waiting for her friends to arrive for over 30 minutes.

- The subject is 'she', so we use 'has been' not 'have been'. This is an example of the **present perfect continuous**, with a situation starting in the past and continuing to the present, with a focus on the duration.

2. Andy had been a teacher for almost 50 years when he retired.

- This is an example of the **past perfect simple**. We use 'had been' to describe the state of being a teacher. There are two past events - first, Andy was a teacher for almost 50 years and then he retired.

3. Have you ever been to London?

- In this question, we use the **present perfect simple** to ask about travel experiences. We use 'have' not 'has' because the subject is 'you'.



4. My bike has been stolen! How am I going to get home?

- This is the **present perfect simple passive**. 'My bike' could be replaced by the pronoun 'It', so we use 'has'.

5. Karim has never been to Mongolia, but he's planning to go next year.

- This negative statement is about a travel experience (or non-experience!). We use 'has' because 'Karim' could be replaced by 'He'.

QUIZ!

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. The feedback from customers _____ very positive this quarter.
 - a. has been
 - b. have been
 - c. had been
2. _____ your friends ever _____ to your summer house by the lake?
 - a. Has / been
 - b. Have / been
 - c. Had / been
3. For the past week, the city _____ engulfed in heavy fog.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been
4. Before moving to London, she _____ living in Paris for five years.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been
5. Which sentence expresses an action completed at an indefinite time before now?
 - a. They had completed the project when the manager arrived.
 - b. They completed the project last week.
 - c. They have completed the project successfully.
6. Since the policy update, there _____ improvements in morale.
 - a. has been
 - b. have been
 - c. had been
7. Why _____ the packages _____ delayed for so long?
 - a. has / been
 - b. had / been
 - c. have / been
8. My phone _____ missing since yesterday.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been
9. Which option illustrates a completed action in the past before another past action?
 - a. We have finished our homework.
 - b. We had finished our homework before the movie started.
 - c. We have to finish our homework before the movie starts.
10. The documents _____ reviewed.
 - a. has been
 - b. had been
 - c. have been

The End!

